brass, Senior General Than Shwe, Vice Senior General Maung Aye, General Thura Shwe Mann and Lt Gen Soe Win, heading the Office of the Chief of Military Security Affairs (equivalent to our DGMI).[2] In the evening was a banquet hosted by the OCMSA, attended by all the other country DAs accredited to Myanmar and their wives, to bid farewell to Col JS Chopra and his wife, and to welcome me and my wife. It was a grand affair and gave us a glimpse of what was in store for us.

The job itself was fairly simple in that the Defence Wing had to act as the interface between the Indian Armed Forces—Army, Navy, Air Force and Coast Guard—and the respective Myanmar counterparts through the OCMSA. This included the planning and execution of the various visits, be it delegations headed by senior officers of the three Services, or of ships and aircraft transiting through Myanmar. The DA also had to attend the Indo-Myanmar Border Liaison Meetings (IMBLM) held on the Myanmar–India border alternately, at Tamu in Myanmar and Moreh in Manipur, India. From planning to execution and submitting the paperwork, any visit took about two weeks of effort. With one to two events scheduled per month on average, this meant that the Defence Wing had its hands full. We looked forward to such visits, as each visit further deepened the relations between the armed forces of the two countries. It also gave us an opportunity to get news of what was happening back home. I was often asked then, and even later as Chief post the coup of February 2021, that through our interactions, were we not indirectly supporting a military government? My answer is that you have to differentiate between the armed forces of a country and its ruling dispensation.

As a country that shares land and maritime boundaries with India, the land boundary is 1643 km, and we have to, out of necessity, interact with our military counterparts. There

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